

CAMPING WEEKEND GONE SIDEWAYS

*I watched him
take my
girlfriend*

EVAN SLATE

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The highway stretched north, Zane's hands resting loose over the wheel. His left elbow hung out the open window, catching wind. The SUV smelled like coffee and pine air freshener dangling from the rearview mirror.

"Next exit," Zane said, glancing at his phone propped on the dash.

Sasha nodded, her fingers tracing nervous patterns on her thigh. She had been quiet for the last twenty minutes, watching subdivisions give way to farmland, then nothing but trees and the occasional gas station. Her hair was pulled back in a pony tail, the end of it resting against her collarbone.

I watched the back of her head from the back seat. The camping gear crowded me on both sides. Tent bags, coolers, a massive duffel. I offered to sit in back. Zane had the gear organized and loaded before we got to his place. My girlfriend slid into the passenger seat with a private wide-eye glare over her shoulder.

The radio played something with a lot of bass. Zane reached over and turned it down.

"You ever been up this way?" he asked.

Sasha shook her head. "I don't think I've been camping since I was a kid. Maybe never, actually."

"You're going to love this spot. Private sites, right on the water. I used to come up here with my brother before he moved to Portland."

"How far is the hike in?" I asked.

Zane caught my eye in the rearview. "No hike. We drive right up to the site. I'm not going make you haul all this shit through the woods." He chuckled.

Sasha laughed. "Good thing."

I looked out the window at the blur of trees. I hadn't been camping in forever either. When Zane mentioned it to Sasha, three weeks ago now, dropping off flour sacks at her bakery, we both assumed it was just talk, the kind of thing people say without meaning it.

But Zane brought it up again the next week. Sasha was clocking out, pulling her hair free from the hairnet. Zane was leaning against the loading dock with that grin he wore, me there picking her up from work

"Seriously, I've got all the gear. Tent sleeps six. You two should come."

Sasha looked at me. Something in her face, curiosity, maybe, or the desire to be anywhere but her apartment or the bakery.

"When did you say you were going?" she asked.

"This long weekend of course. Three days. I'll drive."

I opened my mouth to say we'd think about it, but Sasha said, "Okay" just like that.

Now Zane merged onto an exit ramp, the SUV slowing. We passed a shuttered fruit stand, a church with a gravel parking lot, a faded sign advertising firewood.

"'Bout another forty minutes," Zane said. "We'll hit the campground, check in, set up before dark."

Sasha shifted in her seat, pulling one knee up. "What's the tent situation?"

"Big one. You can stand up in it, got a rain fly, the whole deal. I've got sleeping pads, bags. This is not like backpacking. This is car camping. Basically a hotel that smells like trees."

She smiled at that. I saw it in profile, the way her mouth curved, her shoulders dropping a fraction.

The road narrowed. Trees crowded close on both sides now, thick trunks and undergrowth pressing in. Zane took a turn without slowing much, the SUV leaning into it. My shoulder bumped against a tent bag.

"You good back there?" Zane asked.

"I'm fine."

"There's water in the cooler if you want."

"I'm good."

Sasha twisted around to look at me. "You've been quiet."

"Just tired."

She held my gaze for a moment with a private grin, then turned back. It was already a wild nature adventure for the likes of us, and we weren't even there yet. Her hand moved to the window edge, fingers drumming with the rhythm of the strange music, strange to us, against the frame.

The music went to something older, a woman's voice over acoustic guitar. Zane hummed along under his breath. He drove the way he did

everything else, loose and confident, like he had been on this road a thousand times.

"What's the river temperature like?" Sasha asked.

"It's shallow near the site. Good for wading, cooling off. There's a deeper spot upstream if you want to actually swim. And the big lake's a ten-minute walk if we want to do that instead."

"I didn't bring a real swimsuit."

"Shorts and a tank top work fine. Nobody's out here judging."

She laughed again, softer this time. Her fingers stopped drumming and pulled on her pony tail, combed her fingers through it, examined the ends.

I looked down at my hands. I had packed light, clothes, a toothbrush, a book as usual. Sasha had packed light too, her bag a small backpack shoved between the gear. Zane had enough equipment for ten people, it seemed.

The SUV hit a pothole and everything rattled. Zane swore, grinned, kept driving.

"Road gets worse before it gets better," he said.

Sasha braced her hand against the dash. "How much worse?"

"You'll see." He laughed.

The highway was gone now, replaced by a two-lane road with no centerline. Trees closed in tighter. The light changed to something dimmer, filtered green through the canopy. I could smell it even through the closed back windows, earth and pine and dampness.

Zane slowed for another turn, this one sharper. The SUV tilted as the road became gravel, then dirt. Ruts carved deep from rain, branches scraped the roof.

"Almost there," Zane said.

Sasha's hand moved from the dash to her lap, then back. She sat straighter, leaning forward like she needed to see the hazards.

I watched the trees slide past, thick and dark and endless. The dirt road curved ahead, disappearing into shadow.

The clearing opened before us like something out of a postcard. The river ran along the eastern edge, maybe thirty feet across, water moving over smooth stones with a sound that filled everything. We made the turn into the camp ground. Trees ringed the sites, birch and pine, their shadows stretching long in the late afternoon sun. The air felt different here, cooler, carrying the smell of water and decomposing leaves.

We slowed right down and crawled past one private site after another, the tires crunching stealthily over gravel. Finally Zane turned into what seemed like a tunnel of green boughs, and we emerged into a circular clearing. He killed the engine and sat for a moment, hands still on the wheel, taking it in. Then he was out, boots hitting the ground, moving to the back of the SUV.

"Let's get the tent up first," he said, lifting the tailgate. "Everything else can wait."

I climbed out, my legs stiff from the drive. Sasha stood by the passenger door, turning in a slow circle. Her face had changed. The tension she carried in the city, the way her shoulders hunched, her arms crossed, was gone. She looked at the trees like she was trying to memorize them.

"What are those?" she asked, pointing at a cluster of white-barked trees near the river.

"Birch," Zane said, hauling out a massive bag. "Paper birch. You can peel the bark right off in sheets, use it for kindling."

"Really?"

"I'll show you later."

He dropped the bag near the fire ring, a circle of blackened stones. Then he was back at the SUV, pulling out poles, stakes, a smaller bag of what looked like ropes and tarps.

I grabbed a cooler and carried it to the picnic table, a weathered thing with initials carved into every surface. When I turned back, Zane was walking the perimeter of the clearing, eyes on the ground.

"Here," he said, toeing a flat spot about twenty feet from the fire ring. "Ground's level here, good drainage, close enough to everything but not too close to the fire."

He dropped the bag and unzipped it. The tent spilled out, a mass of beige fabric.. Zane started separating pieces. Poles in one pile, stakes in another, the rain fly folded to the side.

"Sawyer, grab that end," he said, pointing to a corner of the tent body.

I took hold of the fabric. It was thick, coarse under my fingers. Zane moved to the opposite corner and we spread it out. The thing was enormous, easily twelve feet across.

"Sasha, can you lay out those poles?" Zane asked.

She knelt and started organizing them, her pony tail falling over her shoulder. Zane moved around the tent, checking corners, adjusting the lay

of it. I stood holding my corner, waiting for instructions.

"What's that sound?" Sasha asked, her head tilted.

I listened. Something high and rhythmic, coming from the trees.

"Woodpecker," Zane said. "Pileated, probably. Big ones with the red crest."

"I've never heard one in real life."

"They're loud. You'll hear them in the morning for sure."

He came back to where I stood and took the corner from me. "Let's get the poles through. There are sleeves sewn into the tent. See them?"

I looked where he pointed and saw the fabric channels running across the roof of the collapsed tent. He threaded the first pole through with quick, practiced movements, the fiberglass sliding smooth through the sleeve. When he reached the end, he fitted it into a grommet at the corner.

"Got it?" he asked.

"Yeah."

"Grab the other side and lift when I say."

I moved to the opposite corner. Zane counted to three and we lifted. The pole bowed, the tent rising. He secured his end and moved to help me with mine. My fingers fumbled with the grommet, the pole tip slipping past it twice before Zane reached over and guided it in.

"There you go," he said.

We repeated the process with three more poles. Each time, I felt slower than I was supposed to be, my hands clumsy with the stakes and grommets. Zane never said anything, just moved around me, picking up my slack, finishing what I started.

When the tent stood, it towered over us, easily seven feet tall at the peak, the canvas walls taut and solid. Zane walked the perimeter, hammering stakes with smooth, efficient strikes. The mallet rang against the metal with each hit.

Sasha stepped inside through the front flap. "This is huge," her voice came from within.

I followed her in. The interior stretched wide and dim, the canvas filtering the sunlight to a warm amber. There was room for the three sleeping pads Zane was already unrolling, with space left over for gear.

"Where do you want the bags?" I asked.

Zane appeared in the doorway, arms full of sleeping bags. "Doesn't matter. We can sort it out tonight."

He tossed them onto the pads and disappeared again. I heard him at the SUV, the tailgate slamming, his boots on the ground. Sasha knelt and unzipped one of the bags, running her hand over the flannel lining.

"This feels like my grandmother's cabin," she said.

"You had a cabin?"

"Just for a few summers when I was little. I barely remember it."

We hauled in the rest of the gear. Duffels, the cooler, a plastic bin of cooking supplies. Zane strung a rope between two trees and draped the food bags over it, high enough that animals couldn't reach.

"Bear country?" I asked.

"Raccoons, mostly. Maybe a fox. Nothing that'll bother us if we're smart with food."

The sun dropped lower, the light going golden and thick. Shadows pooled under the trees. Zane built the fire, stacking wood in a careful structure. Tinder in the center, kindling leaned against it, larger pieces on the outside. He struck a match and touched it to a piece of birch bark. The flame caught and spread.

We unfolded the camping chairs, canvas seats on aluminum frames, and arranged them around the fire ring. Zane pulled three beers from the cooler, twisted the caps off, and handed them around. The bottles were still cold, condensation beading on the glass.

I sat and drank and watched the fire grow. Sasha had her legs tucked under her, the beer balanced on the chair arm. The woodpecker called again, closer this time.

Zane leaned back, the chair creaking under his weight. "I saw a hawk the other time," he said. "On the same route, coming back from a new cafe on Westlake."

Sasha turned to look at him. "What kind?"

"Red-tailed. Big one. It was sitting on a telephone pole, just watching the road."

"What was it doing?" Sasha asked.

Zane took a pull from his beer. "Hunting. They perch like that for hours sometimes, watching for mice, voles, anything moving in the grass below. This one had something in its talons. Couldn't tell what from the road, but it was tearing into it."

"That's pretty intense," she said, chuckling.

"That's Tuesday for a hawk." Zane grinned. "They're incredible hunters. Vision's eight times better than ours. They can spot a mouse from a hundred feet up."

I shifted in my chair. "How do you know all this?"

"Just paying attention to it all, I guess. You drive the same routes every year, you start noticing things. Which poles the hawks use, where the crows gather, when the deer cross."

"You ever see anything weird up here?" Sasha asked.

"Weird how?"

"I don't know. Unexpected?"

Zane thought for a moment. "Saw a coyote floating on a log once. Middle of the day. And I've seen owls a few times at dawn. Those are always a trip. Silent. You don't hear them."

The fire popped, sending sparks into the darkening sky. Sasha leaned forward, elbows on her knees.

"What's the difference between an owl and a hawk?" she asked.

"Owls hunt at night, mostly. Different kind of vision, different feathers. Hawk feathers make noise when they fly. Owls have these serrated edges that cut the sound. Makes them silent."

"I didn't know that," I said.

"Most people don't." Zane stood and walked to the edge of the clearing, beer in hand. He crouched near a patch of bare dirt and motioned us over. "Come look at this."

Sasha got up first. I followed. We stood behind him while he pointed at marks in the soil.

"Raccoon," he said, tracing the outline with his finger. "See the hand shape? Five toes, almost human-looking. They were here last night, probably, or this morning."

Sasha knelt beside him. "How can you tell it's not something else?"

"Size, shape. Deer tracks are more oval, two toes. Coyote or fox would be more like a dog print, four toes in a different pattern. These are distinct."

She reached out like she wanted to touch the track, then stopped. "Can I?"

"Go ahead. It's just dirt." He laughed.

She pressed her finger into the impression. "It's so clear."

"Ground's soft here. Holds tracks well." Zane stood and brushed his hands on his jeans. "You start looking, you see them everywhere. Who's

been through, when, what they were doing."

We walked back to the fire. A sound came from the woods, low and repetitive. Sasha froze.

"What's that?"

Zane tilted his head. "Barred owl. Hear the rhythm? They say it sounds like 'who cooks for you, who cooks for you all.'"

We listened and call came again, clearer this time. I could hear it, the pattern he described.

"That's amazing," Sasha said.

"Once you know it, you can't unhear it."

We settled back into the chairs, the fire burned down to a bed of coals, the flames lower now, pulsing with heat.

"How did you learn all this?" I asked. "Just from driving around?"

Zane shook his head. "My dad taught me some of it. He used to take us camping when we were kids. But a lot of it you just pick up. You spend enough time outside, you start seeing patterns. What time the birds are active, where animals move, how the light changes."

"We're not like that," Sasha said. "Sawyer and I. We're more the book type."

"Nothing wrong with books."

"No, but it's different. I can tell you about a bird from a field guide, but I wouldn't know it if I saw one."

"It's just practice," Zane said. "You're out here now. You'll start noticing things."

She smiled. "Maybe."

"It's true. You already asked about the birch trees. You heard the woodpecker. You're paying attention."

I took a drink from my beer, the bottle nearly empty now. "I don't think I'd be good at it. The noticing part."

"Why not?"

"I don't know. I'm not observant like that."

"You're observant," Sasha said. "You notice things about people."

"That's different."

Zane leaned back, stretching his legs toward the fire. "It's all the same. You watch, you listen, you connect the dots. Some people do it with books, some with birds. Doesn't make one better."

The conversation drifted. We talked about the delivery route Zane drove, the bakery, small things that felt far away now. The fire burned lower. Sasha yawned, covering her mouth with her hand.

"I'm fading," she said.

"Yeah, we should call it," Zane said. "Long day."

He stood and kicked dirt over the coals, smothering them. The clearing went darker, just the faint glow of embers and the stars overhead. I hadn't realized how many stars there were until now. Hundreds, maybe thousands, scattered across the black.

We walked to the tent, unzipping the flap and ducking inside. Zane clicked on a battery-powered lantern, and the interior filled with soft white light. The sleeping bags were laid out in a row. Mine on the left, Sasha's in the middle, Zane's on the right.

I pulled off my shoes and set them near the door. Sasha did the same, then crawled into her bag. The fabric rustled as she settled in. Zane stripped off his flannel shirt, down to a t-shirt, and climbed into his bag without ceremony.

I lay down and pulled the sleeping bag up to my chest. The pad beneath me was thin but kept the ground from pressing through. The tent smelled like the faint residue of campfire smoke.

Zane reached over and clicked off the lantern. Darkness swallowed everything.

"Night," he said.

"Goodnight," Sasha murmured.

I listened to them breathing. Sasha shifted, the bag crinkling. Zane's breathing slowed, deepened into the rhythm of sleep.

I stared at the ceiling, invisible in the dark, and listened to the river outside. The sound was constant, layered, water over stones. Somewhere in the distance, that owl called again.

The next I knew, light filtered through the canvas, turning everything amber. I woke to the sound of the zipper, the tent flap opening, boots on dirt. Zane was already up, moving around outside with the kind of quiet efficiency that came from practice.

Sasha stirred beside me, her eyes still closed. Her pony tail had come loose in the night, strands of hair falling across her face. She made a small sound and pulled the sleeping bag tighter.

I sat up, my back stiff, and found my shoes. Outside, Zane crouched by the fire ring, arranging kindling. He had a small camp stove set up on the picnic table, a kettle already balanced on the burner.

"Morning," he said without looking up.

"Morning."

"Coffee's almost ready. Mugs are in that bin."

I found three enamel mugs and set them on the table. The kettle began to hiss. Zane stood and walked to the river, splashing water on his face. When he came back, his hair was wet, slicked back.

Sasha emerged from the tent, wrapped in a flannel shirt over her clothes from yesterday. She looked around the clearing like she was trying to remember where she was.

"Sleep okay?" Zane asked.

"Better than I thought I would," she said.

"Ground takes some getting used to."

The kettle whistled. Zane poured water over instant coffee in each mug, the smell sharp and familiar. We stood around the table, drinking, not saying much. The morning was cool, the sun just clearing the trees.

Zane pulled out a bag of bagels and a tub of cream cheese. "Gourmet breakfast," he said, grinning.

We ate standing up, tearing the bagels in half, passing the tub around. Sasha looked at the trees, the river, her face soft in the morning light.

"There's a hawk's nest about a mile from here," Zane said. "On a trail that loops back. You two want to check it out?"

"Absolutely yes"! Sasha said.

I nodded. "Sure."

We cleaned up, packed water bottles, and started walking. The trail began at the edge of the clearing, a narrow path through the trees marked by faded blazes on the trunks. Zane led, Sasha followed close behind him. I trailed a few feet back.

The forest was dense here. Pine and fir crowding close, the ground covered in needles and moss. Zane pointed at a rotting log.

"See that?" he said.

Sasha stopped. "What?"

"Fungus growing on the side. Shelf fungus. Means the log's been down for a while. Good habitat for beetles, salamanders."

She leaned in to look. "It's beautiful. Like layers."

"Nature's recycling," Zane said. "Nothing goes to waste here."

We kept walking. Zane stopped again near a tree with a hole carved into the trunk, about head height.

"Woodpecker," he said. "Pileated, probably. They excavate these for nesting."

Sasha stood on her toes to peer inside. "Is anything in there?"

"Not this time of year. But you can see how deep it goes."

The trail climbed, the ground turning rocky. Zane moved with the same easy confidence he had at camp, stepping over roots, ducking branches. Sasha kept pace, asking questions about everything. What kind of tree is that? What made this hole in the ground? Why are the rocks this color?

I followed, watching them, the way Zane turned to answer her, the way she leaned in to listen, the space between them growing smaller than the space between her and me.

At one point, Zane crouched and poked up something dark on the trail.

"Scat," he said, holding it up.

"What kind?" Sasha asked.

"Coyote, maybe. See the fur in it? They're eating rabbits, mice, whatever they can catch."

She wrinkled her nose but leaned closer. "How do you know it's not a dog?"

"Dogs don't usually eat rabbits whole. And we're pretty far from anywhere someone would be walking a dog."

He flicked it into the brush. The trail leveled out. Zane stopped and pointed up into a tall pine.

"There," he said.

I looked where he pointed and saw it, a massive nest built into the crook of the tree, maybe forty feet up, sticks woven together, easily three feet across.

"Is there a bird in it?" Sasha asked.

Zane pulled binoculars from his pack and raised them. He scanned the tree, then lowered them.

"Here," he said, stepping behind Sasha. He put the binoculars in her hands, then placed his hand on her shoulder, angling her toward the nest. "Look just above the nest, on that branch."

She raised the binoculars. Zane stood close behind her, his other hand coming up to steady the binoculars, guiding her aim.

"I see it!" she said, her voice hushed. "Oh my god, it's huge."

"Red-tailed hawk," Zane said. "Probably the female. They're bigger."

"What's it doing?"

"Just sitting. Resting, maybe. Could be watching for prey."

His hand was still on her shoulder and she didn't move. I stood a few feet back, watching them, the angle of his body, the way she leaned into the direction he pointed.

"Can you see the chest?" Zane asked. "The streaking pattern?"

"Yeah. It's beautiful."

"They mate for life, mostly. If there's a nest, the partner's probably nearby."

She lowered the binoculars and turned, handing them back to him. Their faces were close for a moment before she stepped to the side.

"Thank you for that," she said.

"Want a look?" Zane asked, offering the binoculars to me.

I took them and found the hawk. It sat motionless, head turning in small increments. I watched it for a moment, then lowered the binoculars and handed them back.

We stood for a few minutes watching the nest, then turned and headed back the way we came. The walk was quieter. Sasha asked fewer questions. I watched the back of her head, the way her shoulders relaxed.

When we reached camp, the sun was high, the clearing bright and warm. Zane suggested the river.

"Water's cold but it feels good once you're in," he said.

We changed in the tent, pulling on swimsuits, me in board shorts, Sasha in a bikini with shorts over it. Zane wore swim trunks and nothing else, his chest pale, a tattoo on his ribs.

We walked to the river beach, a stretch of smooth stones and shallow water. Zane waded in to his knees, then dove forward. He surfaced a few feet out, shaking his head, water streaming from his hair.

"Fuck, that's cold," he said, grinning.

Sasha stood at the edge, arms crossed. She dipped one foot in and pulled it back.

"Come on," Zane said. "It's better if you just go."

She stepped in, wincing. The water rose to her ankles, then her knees. Zane swam closer, his strokes smooth. He surfaced a few feet from her, water streaming down his face, his shoulders.

"You got this," he said.

She took another step, the water at her thighs now, and stopped.

She stood in the water to her thighs, arms wrapped around herself. The one-piece clung to her and she kept adjusting the shorts, pulling them down, her shoulders hunched forward.

Zane floated on his back a few feet away, eyes closed against the sun.

"This is perfect," he said. "Cold water, hot sun. Best combo there is."

"It's freezing," Sasha said.

"You get used to it, just go under once, fast. Like ripping off a bandage."

She shook her head. "I'm working up to it."

Zane rolled upright, treading water. "Look at those rocks over there. See how the sun hits them? They'll be warm. Great spot to dry off."

He swam toward the far side of the river where flat stones lined the bank. Sasha watched him go, then looked down at herself. Her arms were still crossed.

"You look fine," I said from the shallows.

She glanced at me. "I feel weird."

"Nobody's looking."

"Zane's right there."

"He's not paying attention."

She dropped her arms, let them hang at her sides, then undid her shorts and peeled them down her legs and off. The water lapped at her thighs. Zane called from across the river.

"Sasha, come check out this rock. It's hot!"

She waded deeper, the water rising to her waist, then her chest. She gasped at the cold but kept moving. When it reached her shoulders, she pushed off and swam. Her strokes were tentative, her head above water the whole time.

I stayed in the shallows, the water at my knees. The current was gentle, the stones smooth under my feet. I watched them on the far bank. Zane climbed onto the rock, water streaming off him, and reached down to help Sasha up. She took his hand and pulled herself onto the stone beside him.

They sat legs dangling, talking. I couldn't hear what they said. Sasha laughed at something, her head tilting back. Zane pointed at something downstream, and she followed his gaze.

I waded back to the beach and sat on the stones. The sun was hot on my shoulders. After a while, they swam back, Sasha's strokes stronger now.

They walked out of the water, dripping, and collapsed onto the beach beside me.

"That rock was perfect," Sasha said, wringing out her pony tail. "Warm and smooth."

"Told you," Zane said.

We lay there, drying in the sun. The heat soaked into the stones beneath us, radiating back up. Sasha stretched out on her back, arms at her sides, eyes closed. Zane sat with his knees up, looking at the river.

"This spot never gets old," he said. "I've been here maybe a dozen times, and it's different every time. Water level changes, animals move through, even the light's different depending on the season."

"Do you come here alone?" Sasha asked, eyes still closed.

"Usually. It's good for clearing your head."

"I can see that."

We stayed until the sun started to drop, the light turning golden. Then we walked back to camp, our swimsuits damp, skin warm from the heat.

At the campsite, Zane pulled out a cooler and started laying out food. Vegetables, sausages, a bag of potatoes. We worked together, Sasha chopping onions on the picnic table, me scrubbing potatoes, Zane getting the camp stove going.

The rhythm was easy. Zane directed without bossing, asking for things, handing things off. Sasha hummed while she worked. I wrapped the potatoes in foil and set them near the edge of the fire Zane built.

We cooked the sausages on a grill grate balanced over the flames, the smell rich and smoky. When everything was ready, we ate off paper plates, sitting in the camping chairs, the fire crackling between us.

The sky darkened. Stars began to appear, faint at first, then brighter. Zane tossed another log on the fire, and sparks scattered upward.

"You ever think about how weird it is that we're the only species that cooks food?" he said.

"I've never thought about it," Sasha said.

"Most animals eat things raw. We're the only ones who figured out fire changes the game."

"Fire and tools," I said. "That's what separates us."

"Tools, sure. But a lot of animals use tools. Crows, otters, chimps. Chimps are wild. They've got social structures that'd put some human groups to shame."

Sasha leaned forward. "What do you mean?"

"Hierarchy, alliances, politics. They know who's in charge, who's allied with who. And they re-negotiate that stuff constantly. Sometimes with aggression, sometimes with grooming, sometimes with sex."

"Sex?" she said.

"Bonobos, especially. They use sex for everything. Conflict resolution, bonding, establishing dominance. It's not about reproduction half the time. It's all social currency."

I shifted in my chair. "That's pretty different from humans."

"Is it?" Zane said. "Humans do the same thing, we just don't talk about it. Power, attraction, jealousy. It's all the same wiring."

"Jealousy's evolutionary, right?" Sasha said. "Mate guarding or whatever?"

"Exactly. In chimps, males guard females when they're fertile. It's all resource competition. Making sure their genes get passed on. But it's not rational. It's instinct. You see a rival near your mate, your body reacts before your brain catches up."

"That's kind of depressing," she said.

"Why?"

"Because it means we're not in control. We're just animals reacting."

Zane shrugged. "Maybe. Or maybe understanding it gives us more control. You know why you feel something, you can decide what to do with it."

I took a drink from my beer. "How do you know all this?"

"Documentaries. Some books. But honestly, a lot of it you can just observe. Go to a bar, watch people interact. It's all there. Dominance displays, flirting, competition."

"You can't compare a bar to a jungle," Sasha said, smiling.

"Why not? Same behaviors, just different setting."

The fire popped. Sasha pulled her knees up to her chest, wrapping her arms around them.

"You really think you can learn that stuff just by watching?" I asked.

"Absolutely," Zane said. "You can read about it, or you can observe it. Books give you theory. Observation gives you the real thing."

"What do you mean?" I said.

He looked at me, then at Sasha, then back to the fire. "I mean if I kissed Sasha right now, you'd learn more in thirty seconds about all this than a

whole book could tell you."

There was complete silence. The fire cracked, a log shifting, sending up a spray of embers.

Sasha let out a nervous laugh, her hand moving to tuck hair behind her ear even though it was already back in the pony tail. She looked at the fire, then at Zane, then at me.

I sat frozen, the beer bottle cold in my hand. My throat felt tight.

"I'm serious," Zane said. His voice was calm, measured. "It can be an experiment. You want to understand jealousy, dominance, how the body reacts to perceived threat? You can read a textbook all day, or you can observe it happening right here and now. Real data."

Sasha's fingers twisted together in her lap. "That's insane."

"Is it?" Zane leaned forward, elbows on his knees. "It's just a kiss. Thirty seconds. And then we talk about what happened, what you felt, what Sawyer felt. It's just ordinary science."

She looked at me. Her eyes went wide, searching my face for something. Permission, maybe. Or a way out.

My mouth went dry. I swallowed, trying to find words. "I don't know."

"No big," Zane said. "Just throwing it out there. But if you're curious, it's a pretty direct way to learn."

Sasha's gaze stayed on me. "Sawyer?"

I felt the weight of the question, the way it hung between us. My chest was tight, my pulse loud in my ears. I wanted to say no, to laugh it off, to stand up and walk away. But the word that came out was different.

"Okay."

It was barely a whisper, but it was there.

Sasha blinked. "Okay?"

I nodded.

She looked back at Zane, then back at me. Her breathing changed, came faster, shallower. She gave a small slow nod, almost to herself.

Zane stood. His movement was slow. He walked around the fire, boots scuffing on the dirt, and stopped in front of Sasha's chair. She tilted her head back to look up at him.

"You good?" he asked.

She nodded again, then laughed with nerves. "I guess! I don't know!"

He crouched, bringing himself to her level, and reached out. His hand cupped the side of her face, his thumb resting below her cheekbone. She

didn't move.

And then he leaned in.

The kiss was soft at first, tentative. His lips pressed against hers, and for a moment, nothing happened. Then Sasha's hand came up, fingers wrapping around his forearm, and the kiss deepened. Zane's other hand moved to the back of her neck, tilting her head, changing the angle.

I could see everything, the way his fingers threaded into her hair at the base of her skull, the way her grip tightened on his arm, the small sound she made, caught in her throat, somewhere between a gasp and a sigh.

It lasted longer than thirty seconds.

When they pulled apart, Sasha's eyes stayed closed for a beat. Her lips were parted, her breathing audible over the crackle of the fire. Zane stayed where he was, crouched in front of her, his hand still on her neck.

Then he stood and walked back to his chair, sitting down like nothing happened.

Sasha opened her eyes. She looked at me, her face flushed, her hand still raised where it had been on Zane's arm. She lowered it slowly.

"So Sawyer," Zane said. "What did you observe?"

I stared at him. My mouth opened, but no sound came out.

"What did you feel?" he asked, his tone gentle. "When you saw that. What was your first reaction?"

I swallowed. "I don't know."

"Yes, you do. Don't think about it, just say it."

"I don't know what I think."

"You do, but you're thinking about it too much. We need data, man! Raw data. What is the one feeling you have right now, no screening it."

The words came before I could stop them. "I didn't want it to stop it."

Zane nodded with a grin. "Now that's data alright."

Sasha was looking at me, her eyes searching mine. "Are you serious?"

"I don't know."

"Didn't it bother you?" she asked.

I hesitated. "I don't know!"

Zane leaned back in his chair. "That's the thing about instinct. It's never clean. You feel ten things at once, and half of them contradict each other, jealousy, arousal, curiosity, fear. It's all there."

Sasha pulled her knees up to her chest, wrapped her arms around them. Her face was still red.

"This is weird," she said.

"Yeah," Zane said. "But informative. Observe, observe, observe."

We sat in silence. The fire burned low, the coals glowing orange. No one spoke. After a while, Zane stood up and kicked dirt over the embers, smothering the flames. The clearing went dark except for the faint light of the stars.

"We should get some sleep," he said.

We walked to the tent without speaking. Zane unzipped the flap and we filed in. He clicked on the lantern, the light harsh after the darkness outside. We pulled off our shoes and climbed into our sleeping bags. Sasha was in the middle, me on her left, Zane on her right.

Zane reached over and clicked off the lantern.

The darkness was complete. I could hear Sasha breathing beside me, slightly quick and slightly shallow. Zane shifted, his sleeping bag rustling.

No one said goodnight. I lay on my back, staring at the tent ceiling I couldn't see. My heart was still pounding. I replayed the kiss in my mind, the way Zane's hand moved to her neck, the sound she made, the way she didn't pull away.

Beside me, Sasha's breathing began to slow. On her other side, Zane's breath evened out, deep and steady.

I stared into the dark, my eyes open, and listened to the river flowing outside unable to make my mind go quiet.

I woke to gray light and the sound of the camp stove hissing. Zane was already outside. Sasha lay beside me, still in her sleeping bag, eyes open.

"Morning," I said.

"Morning."

Her voice was flat. She sat up, pushed her hair back, and reached for her shoes without looking at me.

Outside, Zane crouched by the stove, adjusting the flame under the kettle. He glanced up when we emerged.

"Coffee's almost ready," he said.

"Thanks! Yum!" Sasha said. "So efficient and capable!"

We stood around the picnic table, not quite looking at each other. Zane poured water into the mugs, handed them out. I wrapped my hands around mine, focusing on the heat.

"Everybody sleep okay?" Zane asked.

"Fine," I said.

Sasha nodded, sipping her coffee.

Zane pulled out the bagels again, the cream cheese. We ate standing in the same positions as yesterday, but the rhythm was off. There was too much space between us. Too much quiet.

Zane finished his bagel and wiped his hands on his jeans. He picked up Sasha's mug from where she had set it on the table and held it out to her.

"Here," he said.

She reached for it. Then he leaned in slowly and kissed her even slower.

It was light and brief, his lips barely brushing hers. He pulled back with a small but satisfied grin.

"Part 2 of the experiment," he said, and he laughed.

Sasha let out a breath that might have been a laugh. "You're so ridiculous."

"Just maintaining scientific consistency. Baseline, right? A-B-A-B, right?"

I looked down at my coffee. Zane walked to the fire ring and started arranging kindling.

Sasha gripped her mug in both hands. They were shaking, the surface of the coffee trembling.

"You going to be okay?" I asked.

"Yeah. I'm fine. It's nothing. It's fun."

But she didn't look fine. Her face was tight, her jaw set. She took a sip and walked toward the tent.

We cleaned up breakfast, packed the food away. The morning stretched out, slow and uncertain. Zane suggested we head to the river to wash things from last night and breakfast. We gathered the mugs, plates and utensils, walking down to the beach.

Sasha knelt in the shallows, scrubbing a plate with a brush. Zane crouched beside her, rinsing a pot in the current. I sat in one of the camping chairs we had dragged down, a book open in my lap.

But I wasn't reading.

Zane said something to Sasha, too quiet for me to hear. She laughed, shook her head. He moved closer, his shoulder brushing hers. She handed him a plate, and he rinsed it, then set it on the stones beside him.

Then he leaned in just as slow as before and kissed her again. He was slow enough she had all the time in the world to laugh him off, move away, tell him no. But she turned to him.

This one went longer yet. His hands moved over her hips, pulling her to him. She made a sound, soft and surprised, but her hands came up to his chest, not pushing him away, just resting there.

Their faces slowly twisted at each other's, their mouth working on each others. Her neck extended to keep them engaged when he came back from her.

When they did separate, her face was red. She looked at the water, at the plate in her hands, anywhere but at him.

"Sorry," Zane said. "Couldn't help it this time. That one wasn't science," he called up to me with a laugh.

She let out a shaky laugh, too. "You're impossible, you know that?"

"I know. My bad."

They went back to washing dishes. I stared at the book, the words a blur. My chest felt tight, my breathing shallow. I didn't move.

After a few minutes, they finished and carried the clean dishes back to camp. I followed, the book still in my hand, not new page read.

We ate lunch in silence, sandwiches, chips, water from the cooler. Zane suggested exploring upriver. We set out along the bank with no clear destination in mind.

Zane led, Sasha close behind. I trailed a few feet back.

The river narrowed here, the current faster, the stones larger. Zane pointed at something in the water, a flash of silver. Sasha leaned in to see. Her hand rested on his arm, steadying herself.

They walked side by side now, their steps matching. At one point, the bank rose steep. Zane climbed up first, then reached back. Sasha took his hand, and he pulled her up. His other hand went to the small of her back, guiding her over the rocks.

I climbed up on my own, a few feet to the side.

We kept walking. They talked, their voices low, punctuated by Sasha's laugh. Zane touched her more, a hand on her shoulder when he pointed something out. His arm brushing hers when they walked close.

I watched the distance between them shrink and the distance between me and them grow.

We reached a spot where the river widened into a pool, the water deep and slow. Zane crouched at the edge, looking at something beneath the surface. Sasha knelt beside him, their heads close together.

"What is it?" she asked.

"Trout, maybe. Hard to tell with the light."

She leaned closer, her shoulder pressing against his.

I stood back, hands in my pockets, watching.

After a while, Zane stood and stretched. "We should head back. It's getting late."

We walked back the way we came, the sun lower now, the light golden and warm. Zane and Sasha walked together, her hand brushing his arm, his hand at her back when the terrain turned rough.

When we reached camp, the clearing was bathed in late afternoon light. Zane went to the cooler, pulled out beers, handed them around.

We sat in the camping chairs, drinking, not saying much. The fire was unlit, the ring cold and black. Sasha's chair was closer to Zane's than it had been yesterday.

I looked at the trees, the river, the sky turning pink at the edges. The sun hung low, the light going orange and soft. Zane stood and stretched, looking at the fire ring.

"We need more wood," he said. "Sawyer, you want to help me?"

I set down my beer and followed him into the trees. We walked in silence, stepping over roots and fallen branches. The forest was dimmer here, the canopy thick overhead. Zane stopped near a dead pine, its trunk gray and brittle.

He turned to face me.

"This still cool with you?" he asked.

My throat tightened. "What?"

"This. Me and Sasha. The kissing. All of that." He looked at me straight on, no grin, no deflection. "We can dial it back."

I opened my mouth, closed it, the words stuck somewhere between my chest and my throat.

"It's fine," I said.

The pause before I spoke felt like minutes. Zane watched me, his eyes steady.

"You sure about that? You said you didn't want it to stop yesterday. I'm just going with that."

"Yeah."

He studied my face for a long moment, then nodded. "Okay, just checking."

He crouched and started gathering branches, testing them for dryness, snapping the brittle ones into manageable lengths. I watched him and did the same, moving through the undergrowth, collecting wood. We didn't speak about it again.

When our arms were full, we walked back to camp. Zane dumped his load by the fire ring and started building the structure. I added my branches to the pile and stepped back.

Sasha was at the picnic table, pulling vegetables from the cooler. Zane walked over, wiping his hands on his jeans.

"What are we making?" he asked.

"I thought pasta and salad. Something easy."

"Perfect."

They worked together, Sasha chopping peppers and onions, Zane filling a pot with water from the jug. Their movements were easy, synchronized. She handed him things before he asked. He moved around her without needing to check where she was.

At one point, she stirred something on the camp stove. Zane leaned in, his hand on her waist, and kissed her on the neck. It was quick and casual, like it was the most natural thing in the world.

She laughed lightly too, her body tilting toward him even as she kept stirring.

"You're distracting me," she said with a grin.

"Sorry."

But he didn't move his hand.

When he kissed her again, she turned her face toward him, met his mouth with her mouth. I could tell tongues were involved.

I sat in my chair by the unlit fire, watching. They finished cooking, served out the pasta. We ate around the picnic table. The conversation was light, all surface-level, the weather, the food, the sounds of the forest at dusk. Nothing about what was going on.

After dinner, Sasha gathered the dishes and walked down to the river. Zane followed a minute later, carrying the pot.

I stayed by the fire ring, adding kindling like how I watched Zane to it, and striking a match. The flames caught, small at first, then growing.

At the river, Sasha knelt in the shallows, scrubbing a plate. Zane set the pot beside her, then moved behind her. His hands went to her shoulders and she went still.

He leaned down over her and kissed her neck.

She gasped lightly and chuckled, her back arching, pressing up against him. The plate slipped from her hands into the water. Zane's arms wrapped around her waist, pulling her closer. His mouth moved along her neck, her shoulder, and she tilted her head to give him more of her. She pulled her hair over the other shoulder.

I sat frozen, the fire crackling in front of me, my eyes locked on them in that light down by the evening still and sparkling water.

The kiss deepened. Zane's hands moved over her shirt, tracing her sides, her ribs. Sasha's breathing was visible even from where I sat, sharp and ragged. Her hands came up to grip his forearms, holding him to her.

When they broke apart, she stayed pressed against him, her chest rising and falling. Then she turned her head, looking back toward the fire.

Her eyes found mine.

We stared at each other across the distance. Her face was flushed, her lips parted.

Then she turned back to Zane. He kissed her again, his hand moving to her jaw, turning her face toward his. Her hand slid up into his hair. Her fingers curled and tugged the longer their kiss went this time.

They stayed like that for too long, Zane tugging her hair too, Sasha letting him, her head coming back, her eyes shooting to him, gauging him, before closing again. He kissed her again and again, her chest coming up, her breath catching between the kisses. He tugged too hard on her hair, but it didn't stop her, it only made her chase his tongue with her mouth all the more.

He licked her lips and she chased his tongue, nipping at him playfully. She pushed her hips into his hipbone, ground herself against him. When he kissed her down her neck, she stamped her foot and inhaled sharply, out loud.

When they finally separated, Sasha's hands were shaking. She picked up the plate from the water, rinsed it, her movements unsteady.

Zane said something I couldn't hear and she nodded and bumped him his chest with her shoulder playfully.

They gathered the dishes and walked back up to the campsite. Sasha's hair had come loose from her pony tail, strands falling around her face. Her lips were red, her cheeks flushed.

She set the dishes on the picnic table and sat in her camping chair, pulling her knees up. Zane sat beside her, pulling his chair closer than before.

I stared at the fire, the flames climbing higher. We passed the rest of the evening silently staring mostly, or talking unconnectedly about passing things.

The tent was dark when I climbed into my sleeping bag. Sasha was already inside, lying on her side, facing toward me. Zane was still outside, his shadow moving across the wall as he worked the fire.

Sasha shifted closer. Her hand touched my arm.

"Are you sure you're okay with it?" she whispered.

I didn't answer right away. My throat went tight again, my chest felt heavy.

"I really don't know," I said.

"Do you want us to stop?"

I stared at the darkness above me. "I don't know, I said."

She went quiet for a moment. Then: "You like watching?"

I didn't deny it.

Her hand moved from my arm to my chest, resting light and tentative.

"I feel okay about that," she said.

She leaned in and kissed me soft, brief, her lips barely touching mine. Then she pulled back and settled into her sleeping bag.

The tent flap unzipped. Zane climbed in, bringing the smell of smoke with him. He zipped the flap closed, clicked off the lantern hanging from the center pole, and slid into his sleeping bag.

"Night all," he said.

We mumbled our answers.

But I lay awake, listening to their breathing, and stared into the dark.

Morning came with light filtering through the walls, warm and gold. I woke to movement. Sasha sat up stretching her arms overhead, her back arching. She didn't hunch or fold into herself the way she usually did. She moved like she was completely comfortable in the space.

Zane was already outside. I heard the camp stove, the clatter of the coffee pot.

Sasha pulled on her shoes and stepped out of the tent. I followed a minute later.

She stood by the picnic table, her hair loose around her shoulders, talking to Zane. When she laughed, she leaned into him, her hand resting on his forearm, her body pushing into his shoulder and hip. She patted his ass lightly and laughed, murmuring something funny I couldn't hear. She kissed his neck below his ear and turned away.

We ate breakfast standing, the same routine as before, coffee, bagels, the sun climbing higher. Sasha met Zane's eyes when she spoke, held his gaze without looking away.

After we finished, Zane set his mug on the table and reached for his hat, sitting on the bench. Sasha got there first. She snatched it up, grinning, and held it behind her back.

"Hey," Zane said.

She stepped closer. "Fight me for it."

He moved toward her. She didn't back away. When he reached for the hat, she stood on her toes and kissed him.

His hands went to her waist, pulling her in. She dropped the hat, her arms wrapping around his neck. Their bodies came together hard, no space between them.

I looked down at my coffee.

They kissed for a long time this time, fully making out, pressing together, Sasha's knee sliding up the side of Zane's leg. When they broke apart, Sasha was breathing hard, her face flushed. She laughed, but it sounded different, breathless and hungry.

Zane picked up his hat and put it on. Sasha turned and walked to the tent, her steps loose and easy. She smirked to herself and didn't look at me.

An hour later, we were at the river. Zane had pulled a blanket from the tent and now spread it on the stones near the water. He sat, leaning back on his hands. Sasha sat beside him, then turned and kissed him some more.

I sat on a rock, ten feet away, book open in my lap.

Their kiss deepened. Sasha's hands moved into his hair, gripping him hard. Zane pulled her closer, then pulling her into his lap. She straddled him, her body pressed to his, her hips moving on him as though instinctively.

She made a sound, low, throaty, desperate.

Zane's hands moved over her back, her sides, pulling her loose top up. His fingers traced her skin. She arched against him, her head tilting back.

I couldn't look away.

Her hands went to his chest, pushing him down onto the blanket. When he slid down, she leaned over him, kissing him harder, her hair falling around their faces. His hands moved to her hips, holding her against him.

On her hands and knees, she rocked against him, her breathing loud, ragged. The sounds she made were raw, unfiltered, nothing like the quiet, careful Sasha I knew. I was ten feet away but felt like I was in a different country.

Zane rolled them both over, pinning her beneath him. His mouth moved to her neck, down her collarbone. Her hands clutched at his back, her legs sliding up then wrapping around his waist.

She rolled her head sideways and caught my eye in the gleaming sunshine.

Her gaze locked with mine, her face flushed, her lips parted. She didn't look away, she didn't stop, she didn't push Zane off her.

Zane's hand slid down her bare stomach, disappeared under the waistband of her shorts.

Sasha's back arched up off the blanket, her eyes closing from mine.

I gripped the arms of the chair, my knuckles white, and watched.

He rolled off her finally and they both caught their breath. We made our way back up to the site.

"One more swim before we start packing up?" Zane said.

Sasha nodded and I did the same.

We changed in the tent, pulling on swimsuits without speaking. The air inside was hot, stifling. When we emerged, the sun was high and brutal.

We walked to the river beach. Zane waded in first, diving under when the water reached his waist. Sasha followed, moving slower, her arms wrapped around herself.

Zane surfaced and swam to her. His hands went to her waist, pulling her close. She didn't resist.

He kissed her, deep and urgent. His hands slid down her sides, gripping her hips, then moved lower. His fingers slipped under the edge of her bikini bottom.

Sasha gasped against his mouth. Her hands clutched his shoulders, her body pressing into his. She ground against his thigh, the water rippling around them.

I sat on the shore, the book beside me, unopened. My eyes locked on them.

Zane's mouth moved to her neck. Sasha's head fell back, her lips parted, sounds escaping her that the water couldn't muffle.

They stayed like that, bodies intertwined, until Zane pulled back. He took her hand and led her out of the water.

They walked past me, dripping, not looking at me. I followed them back to camp.

The clearing was blazing with midday heat. Zane went straight to the tent and unzipped the flap.

He looked at Sasha. She looked at me. I froze.

She ducked inside and Zane followed. I stood outside for a moment, then stepped through the flap.

The light inside was diffused, golden, the walls filtering the sun. The air was close, thick with heat.

Zane reached for Sasha. His hands went to her bikini top, sliding the straps down her shoulders. She raised her arms, and he pulled the suit down, inch by inch, peeling it off her body.

She was trembling.

He tossed the top aside and pulled off his own, standing naked in front of her. His hands went to her waist, pulling her close, and he kissed her. His fingers tucked inside her bikini bottom and she only raised herself on her toes to let him push them down her legs. They fell to her feet and she stepped out of them.

His mouth moved to her neck. She tilted her head, giving him full access. He kissed down to her collarbone, his hands moving over her skin. When his mouth closed over her bare breast, she gasped, her hands flying into his hair.

He took his time, kissing, sucking, his tongue tracing her skin. Sasha's sounds filled the tent, raw and desperate.

I stumbled and fell onto the cooler where I sat. I couldn't believe they were both already so completely naked. Sasha never liked being naked with me in light.

Zane moved lower. His mouth traveled down her stomach, her hips. He knelt in front of her, his hands on her thighs, and looked up at her.

She was breathing hard, her chest rising and falling.

He guided her down onto the sleeping bag, spreading her legs. She didn't resist one bit. She let herself be handled by him.

I sat frozen against the tent wall, my eyes locked on them. The tent was small. I could see everything. And hear more.

Zane's head lowered between her raised and parted thighs.

Sasha's back arched off the sleeping bag, her hands curling into fists in the fabric. A tiny cry lilted from her throat.

Zane worked on her with his mouth, his hands gripping her hips, holding her in place though she writhed violently beneath him, her voice climbing, desperate.

Just when her breathing turned frantic, her body tensing, Zane stopped.

Sasha whimpered, her hips lifting, pushing, seeking him.

He kissed her inner thigh, his hands stroking her legs. Then his mouth returned.

He brought her to the edge again. Her sounds grew louder, more frantic. Her hands went to his head, pulling him closer.

He stopped.

"Please," she whispered.

Zane looked up at her, his face wet with her, his eyes dark.

He said nothing. He lowered his head again. This time he didn't stop until she was shaking, her voice breaking. Then, before she shattered, he pulled back again.

Sasha's cry was anguished. She kicked her legs with frustration. Zane laughed, low and rough.

He spread her legs wider, pressed her hips down harder, and lowered his mouth to her again.

Sasha's hand shot down, grabbing Zane's hair, pulling his head back to her.

"Don't stop," she said. Not a whisper, a demand.

Something had changed in her. The shyness was gone. She knew what she wanted now.

Zane's eyes met hers. He grinned, then lowered his mouth to her and this time he didn't stop.

Sasha's body went rigid. Her back arched high, lifting off the sleeping bag, every muscle in her body taut. The sound that came from her throat was primal, uncontrolled. Her thighs clamped around Zane's head, her hands curling into fists in his hair.

I watched her face. The way her mouth opened, her eyes squeezed shut, the way her whole body shook, waves of pleasure moving through her,

visible in every tremor, every gasp... it nearly killed me.

When she finally broke, she collapsed back onto the sleeping bag, her chest heaving, her skin flushed and damp.

Zane kissed her thigh, her hip, then moved up her body. She reached for him, her hands urgent, pulling him down to kiss her.

She tasted herself on his mouth, and the knowledge seemed to ignite something else in her. Her hands moved between them, wrapping around him. Zane groaned against her mouth.

She stroked him, her movements grasping. He pulled back, breathing hard, but she increased her grip.

She sat up, her hands immediately on him, exploring, stroking.

"Lie back," she said.

Zane lay back on the sleeping bag. Sasha moved over him, straddling his chest, facing away from his head. She leaned forward, her mouth lowering to him.

From where I sat, I could see her face in profile as she took him in her mouth. Her lips stretched around him, her eyes closing. Zane's hands moved to her hips, pulling her back toward his face.

She gasped around him as his mouth found her again. His hands gripped her thighs, spreading them, holding her in place above him.

She sank down on him until he was fully down her throat.

Their sounds filled the tent wet and obscene. Sasha moaned around him, the vibrations making Zane groan beneath her. His breathing went ragged, muffled against her body, between her quaking thighs.

She took him deeper, her head bobbing, her hand working what her mouth couldn't reach. Zane's hips lifted, thrusting up into her mouth, while his tongue worked her relentlessly.

Her movements became less coordinated as pleasure overtook her focus. She pulled back, gasping, her hand still stroking him while she tried to catch her breath.

"God," she breathed. "I can't..."

Zane's response was to grip her thighs harder, pulling her down more firmly onto his mouth. She lifted her face directly at me, cried out, her free hand bracing against his stomach.

She tried to focus, lowering her mouth to him again, but her rhythm was broken by her own gasps and moans. Every time she took him in, Zane did

something with his tongue that made her falter, made sounds escape around him that were beyond her control.

I watched her face, the way it shifted between concentration and surrender, the way her eyes would squeeze shut when Zane hit a particular spot, the way her mouth would go slack around him, forgetting what it was supposed to be doing.

Zane's hands moved from her thighs to her hips, rocking her against his face. The tent filled with their sounds, their breathing, the wet obscenity of mouths and tongues and desperate need.

Sasha pulled off him completely, her hand gripping him tight while she gasped for air.

"I'm going to, I can't..."

But Zane didn't stop. His hands held her in place, his mouth relentless.

She came with a cry, her whole body convulsing above him. Her hand stopped moving on him as pleasure tore through her, leaving her shaking and incoherent.

When the waves finally subsided, she collapsed forward, her forehead resting against his thigh, her breathing ragged. Zane's hands gentled on her hips, stroking rather than gripping.

After a moment, she shifted, turning around so she faced him. She straddled his hips, her hands on his chest.

Her hand moved between them, positioning him. She looked over at me, her eyes finding mine in the dim light of the tent. I knew it was one last look. But I could say nothing. I was nearly as gone as they were. I was madly pumping myself and she saw how hard I was in my hand.

Staring at me, she sank down onto him.

The sound she made was raw, her head falling back, her mouth open, her eyes closing. Zane's hands went to her hips, guiding her, and she began to move on him.

It was slow at first, then faster. Her hands braced on his chest, her body rising and falling. The tent filled with the sound of flesh slapping flesh, her gasps, his groans.

She rode him like she had never been shy, like her body knew exactly what it wanted and how to take it. Her movements were fluid like waves, chasing her own pleasure. Her back flowed.

Zane's hands moved from her hips to her breasts, and she arched into his touch, her pace increasing. Sweat gleamed on her skin in the diffused

golden light.

"Yes," she breathed.

Her movements became frantic, desperate. Zane's hips rose to meet her, driving deeper, and she cried out.

She shattered, her whole body seizing, her voice a long cry that seemed to come from somewhere deep inside her. Zane didn't stop, driving up into her through it, prolonging it, until she collapsed forward onto his chest, trembling and spent.

She lay collapsed on his chest, her breathing hoarse, her body trembling. Zane's hands stroked her back, her hair, gentle now.

After a moment, he shifted beneath her. "Roll over."

She lifted her head, looking at him through half-closed eyes. "I can't move."

He laughed and shoved her around. He let her be manhandled. She knew what she stirred in him, she knew what must come.

He helped her off him, guiding her onto her back on the sleeping bag. She lay boneless, her arms above her head, her legs falling open, ready and inviting for him.

Zane positioned himself between her thighs. She watched him, her chest still rising and falling rapidly. He was still hard, and her eyes dropped to look at him.

He lowered himself over her, his weight on his forearms. She reached up, her hands around him, pulling him down, and they kissed. The kiss was slow, deep, different from the frantic ones before.

When they broke apart, she looked up at him.

Zane positioned himself at her entrance. She spread her legs wider, her hands moving to his hips. Then, instead of pushing forward, he slid up, the length of him moving against her without entering.

Sasha gasped, her hips lifting, chasing.

He did it again. Sliding against her, the friction making her whole body tense.

"Zane," she breathed.

She laughed full of shakes.

He slid against her again, slow. He moved again, and she whimpered, her hands gripping his hips, trying to guide him. He adjusted his angle, staying outside, sliding along her..

"Stop teasing me!"

He slid against her again, his eyes on her face. "I love teasing you."

Her hands moved from his hips to between them, trying to position him, trying to take from him what she needed. He caught her wrists, pulling them away.

He pinned them to the sleeping bag above her head, one hand holding both of them. Then he slid against her again, the friction unbearable to her.

Sasha's whole body arched, her head pressing back into the sleeping bag. He moved against her, harder this time, and words died in her throat. She pulled at her wrists, trying to free them, but his grip was firm.

He slid against her again, slower, watching her face. Her eyes went wide, desperate.

"I want..."

"You'll get."

She pouted and whined and bucked hard up against him. She laughed and she gasped with a loud sigh.

He moved against her, the pressure building with each slide. Sasha's hips moved with him, trying to change the angle, trying to make him slip inside her, but he maintained perfect control.

He slid against her again, and she cried out, frustrated and desperate. Tears gathered at the corners of her eyes.

He positioned himself at her entrance, the tip pressing against her. She went completely still, her breathing stopped.

He remained not moving forward with maddening pressure. Sasha's hips lifted, trying to take him in, but he pulled back.

She forced her body to stop moving, every muscle tense with the effort. He pressed forward and she whimpered.

"Zane!" she shouted. "Fuck me for fuck sakes!" She laughed and darted her eyes at me.

He pulled back and slid against her again one more time, still not entering her, though the tip of his head caught on her. The sound she made was anguished, broken.

"I hate you!" she gasped.

Her wrists strained against his grip. Her whole body was trembling, wound so tight she looked like she might shatter.

He positioned himself at her entrance again. This time he pushed forward but barely inside.

I nearly lost it.

He stayed there, not moving deeper, just a tiny intrusion, a promise.

He pulled back, sliding against her again, and she screamed. The sound was raw, desperate, beyond control.

He positioned himself again, the tip pressing inside her.

Her voice was breaking, tears streaming down her temples into her hair. She was beyond shame, beyond pride, reduced to pure need.

He pushed forward, another inch, and stopped. She cried out, her whole body straining toward him, trying to take more.

Her breathing came in ragged gasps. He remained barely inside her, watching her face.

Her voice broke completely on his name. He released her wrists, and her hands flew to his back, pulling him closer.

He pushed forward.

Her face transformed. Her mouth opened wide, a cry tearing from her throat that filled every corner of the tent. Her eyes squeezed shut, her whole body going rigid, then melting, opening, accepting him.

I watched every detail, the way her fingers dug into his back, her nails leaving white crescents on his skin, the way her neck arched, tendons standing out, the way her breasts rose with her sharp intake of breath.

Zane pushed deeper, slower. Sasha's cry turned into a long, drawn-out moan, her head pressing back into the sleeping bag.

"Oh god," she breathed. "Oh god."

He pulled back, almost all the way out, and her eyes flew open, panic crossing her face.

He pushed back in, deeper this time, and words died in her throat. Her mouth remained open, soundless for a moment, then another moan escaped.

I could see the strain in Zane's shoulders, the tension in his jaw. He was holding back, maintaining control, watching her face as he moved inside her.

He pulled out and thrust again at her. Sasha's whole body moved with the force of it, her breasts bouncing, her hands clutching at him.

He found a rhythm, slow, measured, each thrust deep. I watched her face with each one, the way her features shifted, pleasure washing over them in waves, her eyebrows drawing together, her lips parting, her eyes rolling back.

Each thrust drew a sound from her. Sometimes a gasp, sometimes a moan, sometimes his name broken into syllables.

Her hands moved over his back, his shoulders, gripping and releasing. Her legs wrapped around him tight, ankles crossing at the small of his back, pulling him deeper.

Zane's breathing grew harder. His thrusts came faster, the rhythm building. Sasha responded, her hips rising to meet him, her voice climbing.

I watched the muscles in Zane's back flex and release with each movement, the way his hips drove forward with the power behind each thrust, the way Sasha's body yearned for him, opened for him, moved with him.

Her hands slid down to his hips, her fingers digging in, urging him on. "Harder," she breathed.

Zane complied. The force of his thrusts increased. Sasha cried out, her voice raw.

The tent filled with the sounds of their bodies meeting, rhythmic and obscene, Sasha's gasps, Zane's breathing, the wet slide of him inside her.

I watched Sasha's face, the way pleasure built in her features, her eyes unfocused, her mouth slack, and the way she started to tense, her whole body drawing tight.

She shattered beneath him, her back arching completely off the sleeping bag, her cry sharp and broken. Every muscle locked, her hands curled into fists in the fabric beside her head.

I watched pleasure tear through her, the way it moved from her core outward, visible in the trembling of her thighs, the shaking of her arms, the convulsing of her stomach muscles.

Zane didn't stop. He drove into her through it, his rhythm relentless, prolonging her climax, pushing her through wave after wave.

Sasha's cries turned into sobs, her body oversensitive but unable to escape. Her hands pushed at his chest weakly, then clutched at him instead, pulling him closer.

He thrust harder, and she screamed, another wave crashing over her before the first had fully subsided. Her whole body convulsed, tears streaming from the corners of her eyes.

When she finally started to come down, gasping for air, Zane slowed but didn't stop. Long, deep strokes that made her whimper with each one.

He shifted the angle, lifting her hips, pulling her ankles over his shoulders, and he thrust deeper. Sasha's eyes flew open, her mouth forming a perfect O. Her was getting thrashed like a rug.

He thrust again, hitting the same spot, and her words dissolved into incoherent sounds.

I watched Zane's control begin to slip, his rhythm becoming less measured, more driven, his breathing harsh and ragged, the muscles in his back and shoulders straining.

Sasha's hands moved to his face, pulling him down to kiss her. The kiss was messy, desperate, sloppy, more breathing into each other's mouths than anything else.

His thrusts became harder, faster, chasing his own release now. Sasha's voice climbed with his rhythm, encouraging him.

I watched the tension build in Zane's body, watched him drive into my girlfriend with abandon, all control gone. Sasha wrapped around him, holding him, taking everything he gave.

Her body clamped down on him. The sensation pushed Zane over the edge. He drove deep one final time, his whole body going rigid, a groan tearing from his chest.

I watched them both come undone, Zane's face buried in Sasha's neck, his body shaking, Sasha's hands in his hair, her legs locked around him, her voice breaking.

They stayed locked together, bodies trembling, breathing ragged, as the waves gradually subsided.

The tent was thick with heat and the smell of sweat and sex. Golden light filtered through the canvas, turning their skin warm and honeyed.

Neither of them moved until Zane finally pulled out slowly. Sasha whimpered, her body still trembling. He rolled onto his back beside her, his chest heaving.

They lay there for a moment, both catching their breath. Then Zane turned his head to look at her.

"Turn over," he said.

Sasha looked at him, her eyes glazed. "What?"

"On your stomach."

She rolled over, her movements slow and uncoordinated. Zane moved behind her, his hands going to her hips, pulling them up.

"On your knees," he said.

She got onto her hands and knees, her arms shaking. Her hair fell forward, obscuring her face. Zane brushed it aside, gathering it in one hand.

From where I sat, I could see her profile. Her mouth open, her eyes half-closed, her skin flushed and damp.

Zane positioned himself behind her and pushed in.

The angle was different, deeper. Sasha's arms gave out immediately, her face pressing into the sleeping bag, her back arching as she came down to her chest, her ass high in the air behind her.

Zane's hands gripped her hips, pulling her back onto him with each thrust. The sound of their bodies meeting filled the tent all over, rhythmic and vulgar.

Sasha's hands curled into a fist in the sleeping bag, her knuckles white. Every thrust pushed a sound from her, muffled against the fabric.

"Harder," she said, her voice barely audible.

Zane's grip tightened on her hips. His thrusts became more forceful, driving her forward with each one. Sasha's whole body rocked with the impact.

I watched Zane's face, the concentration, the strain, the way his jaw clenched. Sweat dripped down his temple, his chest. His breathing was harsh, ragged.

Sasha reached back, her hand finding his thigh, pulling him deeper.

He leaned forward, one hand moving to her shoulder. The new position drove him impossibly deeper. Sasha screamed into the sleeping bag.

"Oh fuck!"

Of course I'd never seen or heard her anything like that before. Her voice was raw, desperate. I watched her hand clutch at the sleeping bag, watched her body accept each brutal thrust, watched pleasure and pain blend on her face.

Zane's control was fraying again. His rhythm becoming erratic, driven by need rather than technique. His breathing came in gasps, his grip on her hips hard enough to leave marks.

Her body tensed, then shattered. She came hard, her whole body convulsing, a scream tearing from her throat. Zane didn't stop, didn't slow down, driving her through it and beyond.

She collapsed forward and Zane followed her down, his body covering hers, still moving inside her.

The sensation of her climax pushed Zane over the edge. He drove deep one final time, holding himself, his whole body going taut. A guttural groan

tore from his chest as he came, his hips jerking, emptying himself inside her all over again.

I watched them both frozen in that moment, Zane's face twisted in pleasure, his body rigid, Sasha beneath him, tears streaming down her face, her mouth open in a silent scream, her body locked in climax.

That's when I lost it too.

They both collapsed. They lay tangled together, both shaking, both gasping for air. The tent was silent except for their ragged breathing.

Sasha's hands came up weakly, touching Zane's face, his hair. He turned his head and kissed her palm.

Neither of them spoke. Neither of them moved beyond that small gesture.

I sat against the tent wall, my heart pounding, my whole body gone. The golden light filtering through the canvas seemed brighter now, the heat more intense.

Zane slowly pulled out and rolled to the side. Sasha made a small sound, her body curling into itself.

They lay spent and trembling as the afternoon light shifted and the sounds of the forest filtered through the canvas walls.

The tent was silent except for breathing. Three sets of lungs worked to pull air, to slow the pounding of hearts, to return to something approaching normal.

I sat against the tent wall, my body flaccid, my hands gripping my knees. Across from me, Zane lay on his back, one arm thrown over his eyes, his chest rising and falling. Sasha curled on her side beside him, her hand resting on his stomach, her eyes closed.

Minutes passed. The breathing slowed. The trembling subsided.

Sasha opened her eyes and looked at me. Her face was soft, unguarded, her hair a tangled mess around her shoulders. She didn't say anything. I didn't either.

Zane lowered his arm and sat up. He looked at Sasha, then at me, then at the tent walls like he was remembering where we were.

"We should pack," he said. "Time to go, I think." He said it more to himself than to us.

His voice was rough, scraped raw. Sasha nodded, pushing herself up to sitting. She reached for her clothes, pulling them on in silence. Zane did the same.

I couldn't move. I watched them dress, watched them avoid each other's eyes, watched the easy intimacy of moments ago transform into something careful.

When they were dressed, they crawled out of the tent and I finally followed.

Outside, the clearing was bathed in late afternoon light. The air felt cool after the stifling heat of the tent. Zane walked to the tent and started pulling up stakes. Sasha began gathering dishes from the picnic table.

I moved to help, my body operating on autopilot. We worked in silence, the only sounds the clank of stakes being pulled, the rustle of the tent fabric being folded, the thud of gear being loaded into the SUV.

The routine was mechanical. Take down the tent. Roll the sleeping bags. Pack the cooler. Each task completed without discussion, without eye contact, without acknowledgment of what happened.

Sasha carried the last of the dishes to the SUV. Zane folded the tent into its bag. I collected the camping chairs, collapsing them, stowing them in the back.

When everything was loaded, we stood in the clearing for a moment. The fire ring sat cold and empty. The spot where the tent had been showed flattened grass, already beginning to spring back.

Zane walked to the driver's side. Sasha climbed into the passenger seat. I got in the back, surrounded by gear that smelled like smoke and canvas and the forest.

The SUV started and we pulled out onto the dirt road.

The drive was long. Zane kept the windows down, the music low, something instrumental that filled the silence without demanding attention. Sasha's hand trailed out the window, fingers catching the wind.

I watched the trees blur past. The dirt road became gravel, then pavement. The forest thinned, giving way to farmland, then suburbs, then the city.

No one spoke beyond the necessities. Which exit, left or right here, the address again.

The silence wasn't uncomfortable. It was thick, weighted with everything that had happened, everything unsaid.

When we hit the city, the buildings closed in around us. Traffic lights, crosswalks, people on sidewalks living their regular lives. It felt foreign, like we had been gone weeks instead of days.

Zane pulled up in front of Sasha's apartment building. He put the SUV in park and turned in his seat to look at us.

"That was a good weekend," he said with his normal disarming smile.

Sasha smiled. It was small and sounded genuine. "Yeah. It was."

She unbuckled her seatbelt and leaned over the console. Zane met her halfway and they hugged. His hand went to her hair, holding her there for a moment. Then she pulled back and climbed out.

I opened my door and retrieved my bag from the pile of gear in the back. Zane came around the SUV. He looked at me, then pulled me into a hug, brief, warm, solid.

"See you around," he said.

"Yeah."

He got back in the SUV. Sasha and I stood on the sidewalk as he pulled away from the curb, the taillights disappearing into traffic.

We stood there a moment, neither of us moving. Then Sasha turned and walked toward the building entrance and I followed.

The stairs felt steeper, the hallway narrower. She unlocked her door and we stepped inside.

The apartment felt small and stale. The air conditioner had been off for days. Dust motes floated in the light from the window. Everything was exactly as we had left it. But we felt different.

We dropped our bags by the door. Sasha walked to the window and opened it, letting in fresh air and the sounds of the street below. I stood in the middle of the room, not sure where to go or what to do.

She turned from the window and walked to the couch, sinking into the cushions. I sat beside her, the springs sagging under our combined weight.

We sat in silence for a long moment. Then Sasha turned to face me.

"So what did we discover?" she asked. "On our new nature adventure?" She chuckled but stanchied it.

I looked at my hands. The words came easier than I expected. "That watching you was the most erotic thing I've ever experienced."

She nodded, not with surprise, not with judgment, just acceptance.

"Well I discovered that I could complexly let go," she said. "Completely. Because you were there watching, I think."

I looked at her. Her face was open, vulnerable in a way I had rarely seen.

"Are you going to go be with him now?" I said plainly without emotion.

She burst out laughing then stopped herself but laughed again.

"God no! Zane?" She laughed out loud again. "No, baby, no." She cradled my jaw in her palm. "That's not what that was at all. That was..." she looked away. She turned back to me. "That was just sex. I mean," she grimaced and raised her eyebrows. "Very, very good sex, great sex, mind-blowing sex," she laughed again.

"I was there, you don't have to remind me."

"But it was just sex, baby. Just physical. It wasn't at all like with you."

She leaned in and kissed me. It was different from before, deeper, more certain, like she was bringing something back from the weekend and offering it to me, something she had found in herself.

I kissed her back, my hand on her face, and I tasted the weekend on her lips, the river, the forest, the tent. Everything we had been, everything we had seen, everything we had become.

When we pulled apart, she rested her forehead against mine.

"Okay?" she said. She kissed me lightly. "That was just whatever that was, but you and me, we have this."

"Okay," I said.

We sat there on her couch, the window open, the sounds of the city filtering in. "Now if Zane calls next weekend..."

I lifted my face from her neck and she burst out laughing. "I'm just teasing!" she said.

We kissed before she pulled half away. "Sort of." She covered my mouth with another kiss before I could say anything or pull away from her.

But Friday, she came to me where I was reading on the couch and threw her arms around my neck and kissed me warm and deep, saying nothing.

But I knew there was something. "What's up?"

She blushed and glared with narrowed eyes at her phone she held in front of me. "Zane texted." She pursed her lips.

Her breathing rose and her shoulders lifted and her eyes became wide and sparkled. I knew the signs.

"What?!" she protested before I said anything, and her face turned red. "Anyway, didn't you say you liked to watch?"